of a protocol that had been signed between the two foreign ministries which allowed for consultations to take place from time to time. The Chinese agreed. This was the first concrete indication to India that the Chinese may have thought that the policy of 'coolness and isolation' had run its course. Typically, the Chinese made it seem like it was India that was looking to mend fences. The Joint Secretary for East Asia (equivalent to Director General), therefore, travelled to China in February 1999 for a meeting with his counterpart, the Director General for Asian Affairs. This meeting consisted of accusations and counteraccusations, and at one point devolved into a verbal slanging match. This was intentional on the Chinese part. The Chinese vented all their frustrations on the Indian delegation, but they are also past masters in the art of perception management. Hence, when the leader of the Indian delegation met with the Assistant Foreign Minister Wang Yi (now the state councillor and foreign minister of China) later that same afternoon, the latter declared that the Sino-Indian relationship had returned to the correct path. The meeting thus returned the two countries on the path to normality. An immediate outcome was an invitation for the External Affairs Minister to travel to Beijing.

Jaswant Singh visited China from 15 to 17 June 1998. By this time, the Pakistani occupation of the heights above Kargil (on the Line of Control in Jammu and Kashmir) had led to military hostilities, and international public opinion had turned against Pakistan. It had also proved embarrassing for China when a recording of the conversation between General Musharraf, who was in Beijing in the last week of May, and his Chief of Staff, General Aziz, was leaked in the media and established that Pakistan had been responsible for destabilizing the situation in South Asia. The visit of the Indian External Affairs Ministry delegation in February 1999 had helped open the blocked